The next day, I went back to the village accompanied this time by the Sector Commander, Brig DC Katoch, a Kashmiri himself and the DC, Pattan, for some damage control. As it is, the senior hierarchy was quite unhappy with me for having called off the operation, bowing to civilian mob tactics. If this were now to flare up into a major human rights issue, there would surely be repercussions at the national level. We sat down with the village elders; they gave their version of the events and I gave mine—that the civilian deaths were a result of the grave provocation they had instigated. Brig Katoch reasoned with them, that we were doing our job and they needed to cooperate with us, or else the whole village would be branded as terrorists, ineligible for any welfare schemes. Even the Army would not help them, be it for emergency medical evacuation or a hundred other such things that neighbours do for each other. We were part of them; we had never harassed them or demanded any money or any other such petty acts of corruption. 2 RR particularly had a very good HR record. The DC also said some soothing words, assuring them of early settlement of their compensation claims and other benefits due to them but only if they agreed to behave. The elders had some counter-proposals; they would agree to not pursue the issue but only if we agreed to not carry out any operations in their village again any time in the future. This was a ridiculous proposal and rejected outright; they could not become an oasis of lawlessness in an already troubled state. Ultimately, they saw our point of view. We shared a cup of kahwa and some fried chicken—hospitality was always forthcoming among the Kashmiris, and we broke off, if not as friends, at least not as enemies. Another disaster was averted on account of the senior leadership providing much-needed support when needed and through good civil–military synergy. When you are doing your job, mistakes will occur.

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